My views prevailed, though I don't think the CDS was too happy with my stance.

At my final press conference, I was quite at ease. My tenure was coming to an end, and despite the Covid pandemic, we had been able to achieve a number of breakthroughs. I thanked all the media persons for the support they had extended to me and for their responsible journalism. Expectedly my views on Galwan and Eastern Ladakh were sought. I highlighted that the events starting from May 2020 had changed the entire operational paradigm, as I had mentioned on several occasions in the past. We were no longer on the defensive and had imposed costs on China and the PLA, contrary to the narrative being peddled by some China lovers, that only we were at the receiving end. The scale of our deployment and the requisite infrastructure that had been built up had made it clear that a unilateral attempt to change the status quo would be severely contested. The only option now was to get back to the negotiating table, revive the stalled SR levels talks and resolve the boundary question. It could not be business as usual. On Pakistan, I reiterated that we have always wanted peaceful relations with Pakistan and that we are always ready for a dialogue. It was for Pakistan to decide what was in their best interests and whether their so-called strategy of 'death by a thousand cuts' had really paid any dividends. I pointed out that even if their strategy was death by a thousand cuts, the 'thousandth plus one cut' was in our hands and so they would always be at the receiving end.

As far as the region was concerned, the unrest in some of our neighbouring countries, particularly in Sri Lanka and Myanmar, was a matter of concern. Any unrest on our borders, whether land or maritime, has an adverse law-and-order fallout in our border states, so it was in our interest that these countries stabilize at the earliest (Manipur had not happened then). On

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